

BP MEMBER HANDBOOK

**Excellence
through
discipline,
inclusiveness,
honor
and
fitness**

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What is Blazing Paddles?

Blazing Paddles was founded in 1999 as a mixed (male and female), competitive paddling team. The team first competed in the Island City Canoe Race, an annual relay race around the City of Wilton Manors, Florida. The team was fifth overall that year, and second place the next year. In 2001 the race had a mixed division for the first time. Blazing Paddles won the division that year. And every year thereafter for many years. We have been the overall winner of the race, defeating the men's teams, on at least six occasions.

Dragon boats came to South Florida in 2003. Despite being a young and undersized team, BP won every heat it was in and won its division. The next year we won the Fort Lauderdale Dragon Boat Festival at Mills Pond Park, being named Champion of Champions, after edging out the best men's team by two hundredths of a second. The next year the team kept dragon boat racing

alive by putting on a race in Quiet Waters Park, which we won. The event would help lay the foundation for the Synergy Series Dragon Boat Festival. The team continued to race in dragon boats in Florida – at Haulover, Brickell Key, Virginia Key, Marathon and Tavares, as well as at Quiet Waters Park in Deerfield Beach. The team also traveled to Houston and finished second overall in a large festival, missing first place by a small margin. Team members paddled in fusion crews in many other places including Canada and the UK.

In 2009, Blazing Paddles fought its way to the finals of the IDBF Community Division World Championships and in a thrilling photo finish the team claimed its title as World Champions.

In 2021, Blazing Paddles entered the USDBF Club Crew National Championships. The C Division (60 years old and up) small boat crew finished third. The B Division (50 and up) small boat crew finished 4th.

The team also entered paddlers and crews in long distance races. In 2010, members of the team (in a crew then known as Beauties and Barnacles, but renamed Blazing Paddles the following year) smashed the world record for longest race by dragon boat. They also claimed third place overall in one of the most competitive ultra-endurance paddling races in the world, the MR340, which crosses Missouri nonstop. The team successfully defended its title in the dragon boat division in that race in 2012 and 2013. The team also won the Florida Winter Nationals 60 Mile Urban Expedition in 2015 and 2016, setting the course record each time. With team support, several paddlers have made Team USA.

Yes, we train hard to achieve our goals. Lest you think it is all work and no play, the team has a pirate theme and a well-deserved reputation for good sportsmanship and a good sense of humor. We also get together socially off the water.

Our Core Values: Excellence Through Discipline, Inclusiveness, Honor and Fitness

Who can be a member?

The storied history of the team might make you think that you have to be a stellar athlete to join us. It is true that we are eager to have highly fit athletes on the team – however, the biggest prerequisite is a good attitude. Membership and its benefits all remain privileges, and may be limited in the discretion of leadership. If you are team-oriented, positive and ready to work hard to make yourself and your team as good as they can be, then we have a seat in our boat for you. You do not need any experience and you do not need to be in shape. We can teach you all you need to know and, if you are willing to work, get you into great shape.

What are the benefits of membership?

First and foremost, membership brings you into a circle of good friends. Our members include all ages, professions, shapes and sizes. In addition to paddling we often join each other in other adventures and in purely social outings. Everything from mud runs, rock climbing and adventure races to bowling, movies and dinners out.

Membership gets you outdoors. We see marine mammals like dolphins and manatees. Wading birds like great blue heron and night heron. Birds of prey such as osprey. We get plenty of fresh air.

And you'll get plenty of exercise. Stick with it and you will have a strong core, and cardio-fitness – aerobic and anaerobic.

What are the responsibilities of membership?

Members pay nonrefundable **dues of \$300 per year (discounted for early payment – usually \$240 if paid by 30 April)**. Members pay about \$35-60 per race for most races, sometime more, sometimes less (nonrefundable once we commit to a race). You can pay via Venmo (@Will-Murphy-64) or Paypal (SynergySeries). If you want to use a check, make it payable to SOAR, which is the not for profit that owns the boats we use. Our fiscal year runs from 1 July through 30 June, and your dues for your first year are prorated. (If the dues are a hardship for you, speak to the captain. No one will be turned away for economic reasons. Just know that the team is not operated for profit – your dues are needed to pay for the maintenance of the boats and other expenses.) Dues are nonrefundable. Members rendering significant services to the team may receive credit they can use for races and other expenses. To race you will need to purchase a long sleeved race jersey (\$45), and you may also purchase other forms of the jersey.

Each member should also actively serve on one of our standing **Task Forces**. Those are as follows: Fleet Maintenance and Dry Dock (maintains the boats and other equipment); Recruiting and Retention (aka the Press Gang – keeps us well stocked with fresh meat as galley slaves, er, I mean enthusiastic members); Sponsorship and Fundraising (aka Raising Booty); Social (organizes team gatherings). We will sometimes form an ad hoc task force to address a specific challenge. Each task force operates a bit differently. Folks mostly spend 2-3 hours per month on Task Force duties but more is welcome. You may serve on more than one if you wish.

Members promptly and accurately **communicate**, including by answering polls regarding team matters. The team has a members only page on FaceBook. Information there and in other team-only fora is for . . . (wait for it) . . . members only. For practices and most other events, the polls are on TeamSnap. Members should promptly respond to polls, (and a comment saying you will or will not be there may add to but does NOT substitute for actually selecting the appropriate poll response). The Captain or his designee will make a FB post for each practice saying it is ON or OFF. If you don't see a post, inquire. Don't assume that it is on or assume that it is off. If a member's response to the poll should unavoidably change after that comment, the member must personally communicate with the Captain or whoever is leading the event in question and make SURE he or she knows about the change. (A FB comment or email and changing your poll response are good steps but are NOT sufficient by themselves once the practice has been called ON.) Last minute changes should be avoided whenever possible. Often polls will include a "not interested" or "Not applicable" option. If nothing else applies, members should make sure they pick SOME option so that leadership is aware the member saw the poll and has responded.

Failing to clearly and promptly communicate causes extra work and inconvenience for others, and makes it impossible for us to put forth our best efforts. Please stay on top of these things.

Members **support their fellow members**, and treat them with appropriate courtesy and respect and consideration. You should generally NOT coach other members unless asked to do so by the Captain or his designee. We know you intend to be helpful, but experience shows that most members don't want to be coached by other members.

Members **sign up for and come to practice**. Consistently. On time.¹ Ready to go to work.

Members **paddle and train with intention and focus**, paying attention to and following instructions.

Members wanting to **race** in a given event promptly post their **nonrefundable deposit**² to show their commitment to paddling there, and then **show up at the time set by the Captain**, ready to help the team and to race, and they remain until racing is over. Note that races are generally an ALL DAY commitment. If you cannot be there all day, check with the captain prior to signing up and make sure the captain and manager remain aware of your time restrictions as plans emerge and change. When in doubt, do not assume a rain delay or the like means racing is over. If you don't step up promptly to commit to a race you may not have a seat in the boat (and it should go without saying you can't paddle, drum, steer or otherwise compete for another team, either solely or in addition to doing so for BP – the only exceptions are where you committed and paid to race with us if we had that race on our radar IF 1) the captain confirmed to you that we were not racing that weekend, or 2) special circumstances in which you got prior clearance from the captain to compete for another team in addition to BP or in which you got prior clearance from the captain to assist another team instead of BP where BP was not able to offer you an opportunity even though you committed early).

Members **step up** to help **overcome any challenges the team faces**. This is a **TEAM**. **YOU**

¹The announced time is the time to be at the boats, ready to help move them. Of course, whoever gets there first should have the bigfoot out, along with an oar and the safety bag, which is a dry bag that in Hollywood should be hung on a rod in the boathouse about 3 ft off the ground on the west about at the middle of the southern half of that wall and in Palm Beach County should be in the gear box. And as soon as we have enough people to safely move a boat, the first one can go to the water. (The exception being on those occasions when it is unclear whether we will be taking the big boat.)

² Note that the fee to race is discounted for early registration, and the amount goes up as race day gets closer. If you don't see a scale, expect about \$5-10 off for committing and paying more than 8 weeks in advance, listed amount for 4-8 weeks early and \$10-50 more if less than 4 weeks beforehand. Further, our entry may be canceled if we don't get critical mass at LEAST 4 weeks out. If you were not committed to racing with us by that point, you should NOT then make yourself available to race for another team.

have to help it to succeed. The bare minimum is not what we are looking for in a teammate.

Members pledge and deliver their **undying loyalty** to Blazing Paddles.

Race Member or Ready Reserve or Recreational Member While the basics are the same for both, each member chooses to designate herself or himself as a Race Member or Ready Reserve Member or Recreational Member. Race Members get the first opportunity for a seat in a race crew. Once all Race Members have had a chance to enter a race, the Captain will select either Club Members, or friends of the team to fill remaining seats. Note that you do NOT need experience or fitness to be a Race Member. It's about your commitment, not your current ability. *The details as of this writing are set out in Appendix A to this Handbook.*

What are our Standard Operating Procedures (SOP)?

There are certain things we do regularly that work best if everyone is on the same page.

Hollywood:

Launching Boats -----

Those early to arrive can remove the cover from the upright boat, and get oar(s) from the boathouse (the key to the boathouse is in the metal box on the trailer, and is on a lanyard) and unlock the bigfoot from the trailer. The cover should be kept off the ground. We will need ALL HANDS to help get the boats on the bigfoot and launched into the water. When you hear the call for "All Hands" you should immediately go to the boat and help with it. From here on, there needs to be one person coordinating the movements. For the boat that is upright, a couple of people can lift the bow while a third pulls the front stand out. Another can then wheel the bigfoot so that it is aligned with the boat, and under seats five and six (for the mini, under seat three, which usually means almost touching the rear stand), and do so without running into anyone. Those holding up the bow can then gently lower it so the boat is resting on the bigfoot. They may need to gently push the bow down to let the boat roll away from the rear stand. The boat must be taken to the ramp and the bigfoot can be rolled into the water. Note that the ramp can be VERY slippery. Be careful. The castors should not be allowed to enter the water. Members can then lift the end of the boat that is pointed away from the water (usually the stern) and walk her forward into the water while other members keep the bigfoot from moving with the boat. Lifting the boat toward the other end actually makes it HARDER to launch. Lift the part of the boat that is furthest from the water. Never use the steering arm to lift the boat. When all boats are launched the bigfoot should be locked back to the trailer, and the boathouse locked and the boathouse key secured.

Launching boats that are stored upside down is more challenging. Again, there should be one person (the Captain or his designee) coordinating the movements. In general, the boat will remain upside down until it is over the bigfoot. It will then be rotated in a predetermined direction, while the paddlers near the ends of the boat focus on keeping

her up. Everyone should continue to lift and support the boat throughout this movement. **The steering arm LOOKS like a good handle to lift and turn the boat. It is NOT and should never be used for this.** It is essentially glued to the boat and is easily damaged.

Of course, before we can paddle we all need to get into the boat and before that we each need a seat assignment. These are usually made on the dock with the boat or boats already in the water. Except for the one or two people needed to hold the boat, everyone should be on the part of the dock that runs north and south until assigned to a seat. They can then take their gear with them as they get in the boat in their assigned seat.. This helps the person making the assignments know who has already been assigned and where.

Landing Boats ----

Paddlers exit the boat one at a time, as directed. One paddler should stay with each boat to keep her at the dock. All other paddlers should then go to the ramp. The paddler remaining with the boat should turn it so the stern faces the ramp, without letting the boat touch the floating dock. The boat should be placed on the bigfoot smoothly. As when launching, the key is to lift the end of the boat that is toward land (in this case usually the stern). Lifting the other end can be counterproductive. One person can get started on rinsing the gear while the boat is being brought out of the water. This is another “All Hands” situation – no one should be idle.

Putting Boats Away ---- once the boat is on the bigfoot it should be rolled to the boathouse for cleaning. It should be positioned to anticipate the need to wheel it back to storage and put it away, stern first. Once at the boathouse, one person will use a hose to rinse the boat, starting with the inside. The key to the padlock on the gate controlling access to the hoses is in the boathouse on a hook over the podium by the door. It is attached to a black rudder for a rowing shell. Others can use brushes, sponges or clothes to help clean the boat and bailers to empty it, and can feed the hose past the bigfoot wheels so the person with the hose can reach all of the far side of the boat. The person with the hose has right of way since there is only one. He or she will also rinse the outside, *including the center section of the bottom*. (The boat has five exterior sections and each should be rinsed – water on a higher section will drip off before reaching a lower one). Once the boat is cleaned, if it is to be stored upright the cover can be placed on it while it is still by the boathouse – the light is sometimes better there – except that the bungees over the center section should not be attached until the boat is on the stands. (Otherwise the bungees will be around the bigfoot and will have to be removed so the bigfoot can go back to the trailer).

Before we leave, the bigfoot should be locked to the trailer, the hoses should be neatly on their spools with the water shut off, the oars stowed on their pegs in corner, club paddles on their pegs – longest ones to the right and they are color coded white, red, yellow, blue for 51, 50, 48 and 46 inches respectively, and PFDs on rails in the corner. The key to the storage yard padlock should be hanging on the hook over the podium just

inside the boathouse door, and the yard and boathouse locked. Any water bottles or other items should be taken or thrown away (placed in recycling bin) as appropriate. (Reusable water bottles are both cheaper for you and better for the environment than disposable ones.) The boathouse key should be put back in the box on the trailer which should be locked. Our area should be free of trash.

On weeknights when the park is closed by the time we finish, we must lock the gate behind us.

PALM BEACH COUNTY:

We anticipate again having a Palm Beach County location in early 2024. John Prince Park has miles of shoreline on lakes, canals and natural waterways. It is conveniently located near I95 in the Lake Worth area and is easily accessible, particularly from Boca Raton and West Palm Beach. Procedures there will be similar but not identical.

Launching:

For John Prince, the launch may be challenging. The procedures are largely similar. The boat cover should be removed, starting at the stern and rolling forward to the bow. The cable lock must be unlocked and moved out of the way. The bigfoot will already be positioned under the middle of the boat. A few people lift the bow (do NOT lift away from the bow – this makes it harder) and someone pulls to the side the stand that is closest to the water. (The stand near the bow need never be moved). Set the boat gently on the bigfoot. Lift the bow slightly off the front stand so you can roll her toward the water. The person leading may have you place your paddles etc into the boat. Once the boat is in a couple feet of water the person leading the launch will have two people hold onto the bigfoot while the others move to the bow and then lift the bow and walk the boat off the bigfoot. If you're doing it right, the boat will not touch the bigfoot once you lift it.

Landing:

Getting the boat back on the big foot is largely the reverse of taking it off. Two people can bring out the bigfoot and get it under the boat. Then many hands should be at the bow to lift it and walk it toward shore until the bigfoot is under the middle of the boat. Once on level ground the boat can be washed inside and out (all five panels of the exterior) and bailed. Then all hands roll to put the bow back onto the front stand (which need never move). Lift the stern and replace the other stand. Tilt the boat so that right side is higher than the left. Once she is bailed out, the lock cable goes through the big foot, into the boat, through a middle bench and through the drummer's seat which should be set down between middle rows, then locked so the lock sits on the drummer's seat and not in the bottom where it could be very wet. The loop from one end goes through the other loop and then the lock through the projecting end of the first loop. If the heads and tails are being stored in the boat they need to be padded and treated very gently. They are delicate. And the horns should not be used for lifting or moving them except right at the base. The cover goes on, starting at the bow and rolling back. If you are

passing the bungees make sure to turn your face away before letting go so if the person on the other side lets it slip it won't hit you in the face. Gear gets rinsed and then replaced in the storage chest and that gets locked. Our storage area gates should be locked.

On Water Safety and Capsize Procedures

All members are required to wear a PFD (personal flotation device fka life jacket or life vest) whenever in the boat. If you use an inflatable, it must be worn properly (in front) and must be set up to inflate automatically in the event of immersion. We do NOT recommend using manual inflation PFDs for practices.

Paddlers seated in the front should confirm that there are two bailers secured at the front of the boat before launching. If you are a poor swimmer remind the captain or other leader of this.

In the unlikely event of a capsize (we have had just one accidental capsize in a dragon boat in the years since we started in 2003), try to keep your paddle low so you don't hit your seatmate as the boat goes over. Try not to lose your paddle. Stay with the boat.

Find your seatmate. If you were in the first occupied row also find the drummer. If you were in the last occupied row, find the steersperson, too. (This is the "buddy system"). If you are having trouble locating a teammate they are probably under the boat. There is plenty of air there, and the teammate needs to take a breath and duck under the side. The captain or in his absence the steersperson will ask everyone whether anyone is missing his or her buddy(ies). You should only respond if you do NOT have your buddy, or if your buddy announces he or she cannot find you.

Once all are present and accounted for, the captain or his designee will give directions to roll the boat and get back in and bail it out. Typically one to three paddlers will hold all of the paddles and other loose items while the others right the boat and get in to bail it out. Note that we will typically bring paddlers back in over the bow or stern rather than the side, and only as we get the boat bailed out enough to allow more paddlers in it. If you believe you will be unable to get back in the boat without assistance, you should request not to be the last in the water, so that a crewmate can help you. If a motor boat approaches its operator should generally be discouraged from coming too close and no lines should be attached to the dragon boat without the captain's consent.

Paddling the Boat

The Stroke

We are going to break down the standard stroke into these five phases³:

- 1) Set up – this is how you position yourself and the paddle right before the paddle goes into the water.
- 2) Entry – getting the paddle blade into the water (we will teach two versions of this)
- 3) Power phase – applying force to the water with the blade of the paddle (I will offer you an alternative to the way I recommend you complete this phase)
- 4) Exit – getting the blade out of the water (we will teach two versions of this)
- 5) Recovery – returning to the set up position (we will teach two versions of this)

Set up

Just as a good start is particularly key to having a good race, a good set up is the key to having a good stroke. Neither one guarantees that the rest will be good, but a bad one makes it very likely that what follows will be bad, too.

If everyone in your boat does this correctly, and at the same time, you are well on your way to fast race times.

Slide all the way to the outside of your seat, until your hip is against the gunwale (the side of the boat).

Place your outside foot (when seated on the right side of the boat, your right leg is your “outside” leg as it is closer to the side of the boat) braced against the ridge on the bottom of the boat. If you are too short to comfortably brace with your heel, use the ball of your foot.

Lean forward from the hip, with spine aligned, not curved forward.

Rotate your upper body, again, all the way from the hip, so that your chest faces about 60 degrees inward from the centerline of the boat. That is, if the bow or front of the boat represents a 12:00 o’clock position, your shoulders and chest are turned to face about 10:00 o’clock while you paddle on the right. (And as you might anticipate, if paddling on the left, you would be turned to face 2:00 o’clock.) Note that you are NOT simply turning your head in that direction.

³ It is possible to analyze the dragon boat stroke as consisting of more or fewer than five (5) phases. We think this analysis will be clear and useful.

You should have your head turned toward the front of the boat so you can see when the stroke begins each stroke and make sure you are exactly synchronized with them.

Your bottom arm, that is the arm on the side of the boat on which you are paddling and the hand of which is holding the paddle closer to the bottom, is straight. This is very important. A bent arm means wasted energy. Your bottom hand is about one fist above the top of the blade. Some paddlers will find a position slightly above or below this works well for them, but this is a good starting point. New paddlers sometimes tend to take a grip much further from the blade of the paddle and this can make it harder for them to control the paddle precisely.

Your top hand is in front of your head and at about the same level. Your paddle shaft is angled back toward you, but not sharply so. Your top hand is over the water or over the gunwale, so that the paddle shaft is either straight or angled in only slightly.

When viewed from the side of the boat on which you are paddling, your arms, body and paddle should look something like a capital “A”. Some paddlers refer to this as an “A-frame” set up or just an “A.”

Take a firm but not tight grip on the paddle. A death grip will only make you fatigue faster and, if you keep it up long enough, give you tendonitis. Having been there, I will tell you that you are better off breaking this habit before you do enough paddling for it to cause this problem.

This position will feel unnatural. It will initially be uncomfortable and difficult to maintain. But if you and everyone on the team is in this position at the same time just before each stroke, you won’t need to get into it for very long, because we are going to finish races fast!

Entry

The most important thing about the entry of the blade into the water is that it happens at the same time for each paddle in the boat. The paddle should be nearly vertical. Its power face should be directed 180 degrees from the boat’s direction of travel. (See a further discussion of this last detail below.)

Another important point about the entry phase is that it be completed *before* the power phase begins. The first few inches of the stroke are the most important part of it. If the paddler begins to pull the blade back prior to getting the blade fully engaged with the water (fully submerged), a portion of the possible power is going to be lost.

The blade goes in, hopefully quietly and smoothly. It is speared in, pushing down with the top hand. (When you master the basic stroke, you will start to slice the blade in sideways instead). Only after *all* of the blade is in the water should the paddler begin to pull the blade back.

Another common error in the entry phase is not fully engaging the paddle at any point.

The paddler gets the blade mostly in the water and then pulls back, never submerging the entire blade. The blade of a standard IDBF dragon boat paddle has a small surface area. If you leave even 5% of it out of the water, you are losing an important portion of the potential power. When races are decided by fractions of a second, you just can't afford to give that up.

Paddlers all want to develop a long stroke, which is good. Sometimes paddlers angle their paddle shafts strongly back to put the tip of their paddle blade further in front of them. They reason that this gives them a "longer" stroke. The problem with this is that when the face of the paddle blade is facing down, it is only possible to push water down or pull it up. You want to exert force on the water by pulling it back.

Sometimes a paddler turns the blade a bit toward or away from the boat, more commonly the former. The blade should be perpendicular to the centerline of the boat, and the face of it positioned to apply force directly opposite to the direction of travel. Positioning the blade of the paddle to face in towards you, rather than straight back, wastes energy.

Finally, the blade needs to be placed properly vis a vis the side of the boat. The paddle blade should be in the water close to the side of the boat, but should not hit or scrape it. For paddlers in the first three to four rows, the paddle should not enter the water right next to the gunnel. As there is a curve to the gunnel in those rows, the blade should enter the water a few inches away from the hull, so that it can travel in a straight line back, parallel with the centerline of the boat. At the end of the power phase the paddle will then be very close to the side of the boat. Similarly in the back of the boat, the side of the hull curves in, towards the centerline of the boat as the boat narrows. Paddlers there should plant their blades in the water very close to the side of the boat. As we will see in the next phase, when they bring it back in a straight line, the blade will exit the water a few inches away from the hull.

The Power Phase

This is probably the most overanalyzed and least understood phase of the stroke. If you were in a proper set up position, and then properly inserted your paddle blade into the water, then here is what you should do to complete a good stroke: exhale as you sit up straight.

Seriously, don't make this hard. Keep the blade in the water, sit up straight and rotate your shoulders ("untwist") so that they align with the bench on which you are sitting (with your outside shoulder moving back). Your bottom arm was straight – keep it that way. The blade was completely in the water and facing back directly away from the direction of travel – keep it that way. If you do this, you are going to use the strong muscles of your back, hips and abdomen to pull the paddle through the water as you sit up. The force you exert on the water is going to create an equal and opposite reaction and, if your teammates all do the same thing at the same time, the boat is going to *leap* forward in a most gratifying and exciting way. You're dragon boat paddling!

One other thing during this phase – try to keep the paddle shaft vertical.

Exit

The most important thing about getting your paddle out of the water is doing it at the right time and place. The right time is when everyone else on the boat does. The right place to start taking the paddle out is where it is when you have finished sitting up in the power phase. This should be just behind where the kneecap of your outside leg is. It should NOT be back at your hip or behind you.

You should not be bending your arm, using your biceps to draw the blade behind you in the water.

Drop the top hand in and down toward the center of the boat, using your bottom hand as a pivot point so that the blade of the paddle comes up sideways, slicing out of the water.

Recovery

No, this is not what you do after practice with your teammates and a cold beer. I am talking about getting the paddle from the exit, back to the setup.

Using the exit described above, the outer edge of your blade slices out of the water as your top hand drops in toward the center of the boat and down to about shoulder height or a bit lower (but not into your lap). With your top hand, rotate the paddle so that the front face of the blade (the side that was facing away from you during the power phase) is facing down toward the water and slightly forward. (The back face of the blade will be – ready for this? – facing up and slightly backward). If you straightened the thumb of your top hand, it would be pointing forward. Extend the bottom arm, twist your torso to face your chest toward the center of the boat, and lean slightly forward to return to the set up position. Position your hands so that as you make that motion, the blade stays close to the water.

Putting it all Together

Transitioning smoothly through the phases of the stroke will help you be efficient. There are a few other details that will help.

Breathing. Oxygen is your friend. Sounds obvious, right? Get in the habit of exhaling firmly during the power phase. Be especially aware of this on the first stroke of any race.

No death grip. Many paddlers will latch tightly onto the paddle, particularly when they are trying to paddle very hard, such as at the beginning of the race, and late in the race when trying to fight through fatigue. You should have the fingers of your bottom hand (the hand closest to the blade of the paddle and the water) curled with just enough tension to keep the paddle from pulling through. The thumb need not be clamped down at all, and you can rest it lightly on the tips or nails of your middle three fingers. During the power phase, your top hand can be even more relaxed

Don't get overwhelmed. There are a lot of little things that go into a good stroke. When you're beginning, it is easy to feel overwhelmed. Just keep trying to improve with each stroke.

Take the time to get good at the set up phase. If you can get that right, usually what follows will be at least decent. Without it, there is no way to get in a proper stroke. Almost everyone struggles a bit at first. Just be patient. And don't force it. When you're learning, if you become tired during a drill, better to take a short break until you can focus on proper technique. Anything else is just reinforcing bad habits.

Basic Commands

Your steersperson will use the following commands to control the boat. It is important that you respond to those commands quickly and efficiently. Please keep conversation in the boat to a minimum so that everyone can hear the commands. It is a mark of a well-disciplined crew that all hands respond to commands and they do so promptly. This helps with safety and looks cool.

“Back Paddle” – what it sounds like. Turn back over your outside shoulder with your paddle blade just above the water. On the command “Ho” put your blade in the water and rotate forward, pushing water toward the front of the boat. The boat will move backward. Isn't physics cool? The sequence will be “Back Paddle. Set. Ho!”

“Let it Ride” – stop paddling and remove your paddle from the water, letting the boat glide. This is a very popular command at the end of the race. But wait for it.

“Take it Away” – start paddling when you hear “Ho!” or “Go!” A typical sequence is “Nice and Easy. Take it Away. Ho!”

“Set” – also **“Ready ready”** or **“Paddles Up”** Assume the ready-to-paddle (not the ready to be paddled) position. For most teams, this means leaning forward, the bottom arm (hand near the blade of the paddle) extended, the blade poised just over the water. When it is time to paddle, **“Ho”**

“Hold the boat” – “Hold water” or “Hold hard” Put the paddle blade in the water to stop the boat. You must respond to this command, and the others, quickly. “Hold Hard” usually means your crew is not acting fast enough to stop the boat. Insert the blade all the way into the water and push it forward to slow the boat more quickly. If you slack off and let the boat crash, expect a bill.

“Skeg” – similar to “Hold the boat” but turn the paddle 90 degrees so it faces you and put it in deep, past the hull. Helps slow the boat from being pushed sideways by a crosswind. (Some other teams call this a “rudder.” A rudder moves so that a moving boat will turn. A skeg is fixed and helps a still boat hold its position or a moving boat hold its course. “Skeg” is the correct term for this technique.)

“Draw” – not an invitation to a gun fight. This means to turn to the side, place your paddle blade in the water so that it faces you and draw water underneath the boat, pulling the boat sideways. This is usually used to get the boat to the dock when you are next to it, or by the first

and/or last row(s) only to correct the angle of the boat. If the command is “Number one, draw left” then ONLY the paddler on the left side of row one will draw stroke. Do NOT capsize the boat by leaning out when using this stroke.

“Flare the boat” – also **“outriggers”** or **“steady the boat”**. Place the blade of your paddle just under the surface of the water and parallel to it (flat). Hold firmly. This makes the boat more stable.

Note that your drummer will be looking straight back at the steersperson, and can help to relay commands that not all paddlers hear.

The Racing Start Sequence

Most dragon boat races are sprints, 500 meters being the most common race distance. As such, the start of the race is usually critical. Each team uses its own sequence of strokes to start each race. For BP, the sequence is 5+10-5-4-3-2-1 and two counts of four. What does that mean?

First five strokes are long, hard and deep. There is no pause after that, but the counting begins again at 1 and proceeds to 10. For those 10 strokes (often called the “ramp up”) the stroke rate gets a bit faster after each 5 strokes, and someone in the boat will usually call out “up” after stroke number 5 as a reminder. The pace at the end of the ramp up is quite fast and most new paddlers struggle a bit with it at first. Just try to stay on the beat, even if your stroke is very short.

There is no pause after the end of the ramp up, but during the ensuing five strokes, the count is 5-4-3-2-1 and the stroke rate falls back down. The count then starts again at 1, and the count of 1-2-3-4 is repeated twice. The stroke rate is at “race pace” or the pace that it will remain at or near for the rest of the race (with some possible exceptions beyond the scope of this manual). Power must be high to keep the boat moving.

Outrigger Canoe

In 2021, SOAR/BP with help from BP members who made donations, purchased an OC6, an outrigger canoe for six paddlers. Access to the OC6 is first given to the Donor Paddlers. You can be one of them for \$180 per year or \$150 per year for the period from when you add this until the end of 2026 (in addition to your basic BP dues). There may be opportunities for BP members who are not Donor Paddlers to paddle in the OC6 for \$10 per outing, on a space available basis. Outrigger canoes are able to race on the ocean and races are typically 8-12 miles.

FINAL THOUGHTS

Seven Fundamentals of Dragon Boat Paddling:

Number One – Timing

Number Two – Technique

Number Three – Timing!

Number Four – Conditioning

Number Five – Tacos!! Just kidding, it's Timing.

Number Six – FIGHTING SPIRIT!!!

Number Seven – Timing.

On BP we have identified Seven Keys to Dragon Boat Excellence. There WILL be a quiz --

1. Come to Practice
2. Live Like an Athlete (eat healthy food in appropriate amounts, get enough sleep, work out, etc.)
3. Come to Practice
4. Build the Team (through recruiting, fund raising, etc.)
5. Come to Practice
6. Intensity
7. Come to Practice

APPENDIX A

SELF SELECTED MEMBERSHIP TYPES.

What is NOT different:

Dues.

TF Service.

Ranks (Cabin Kid, Scallywag, Buccaneer, Pirate, Corsair).

What IS different

REQUIREMENTS

Type	Erg	OC1	Fitness testing	Relevant Workouts required ⁴	Logging	Practices ⁵
RACE	Quarterly	Every 6 months	Every 6 months	3/week not counting paddling practices	Monthly logs, updates weekly	8 each month. 110/yr
READY RESERVE	Quarterly ⁶	See note 6	Encouraged. Not required	Encouraged. Not required	Encouraged. Not required	4 each month. 50/yr,
RECREATIONAL	Encouraged. Not required	Encouraged. Not required	Encouraged. Not required	Encouraged. Not required	Encouraged. Not required	No minimum

⁴ Not counting paddling practices

⁵ Includes team workouts, OC6/canoe practices, erg workouts. If schedule makes compliance impossible substitutions allowed

⁶ May substitute oc1 trial for every other erg trial

PERQs

TYPE	RACE REBATE	TEAM USA SUBSIDY	MONTHLY HIGH PERFORMA NCE PADDLE	MONTHL Y HIGH PERFORM ANCE LAND/GY M WORKOU T	LEAD OR HELP DESIGN A PRACTIC E ⁷	RACE SEAT PRIORITY ⁸
RACE	\$10 each race ⁹	\$100 for trial/camp. \$100 for worlds if selected	Auto invite. Free	Auto invite. Free	On your request twice per year	First – before Ready Reserve, Recreational and non members
READY RESERVE	NA	NA	By special arrangement	By special arrangement	By special arrangement	After Race, before Recreational and non BP members
REC REATIONAL	NA	NA	By special arrangement	By special arrangement	By special arrangement	None

Race – red ribbon on PFD.

Ready Reserve – yellow ribbon on PFD

Recreational – blue ribbon on PFD

⁷ Subject to Coach approval. If leading, must follow plan except as safety requires (e.g. cutting short due to lightning)

⁸ Once race seats are opened up to the next group, your seat is only assured if you are paid up, signed up and current in all requirements.

⁹ If show up by call time and make all debriefs, marshalling, meetings etc on time and otherwise meet all expectations.